



"I am a student entrepreneur looking to open a casual, quick-service Korean fried chicken restaurant on Green Street in Champaign, IL. My budget is \$150,000, and my target audience is UIUC students. Provide a market analysis and a detailed concept plan."

Green Street in Champaign, IL, offers high foot traffic from over 60,000 UIUC students, many of whom eat fast food 1-3 times weekly due to busy schedules and convenience.^{[1] [2] [3]}

Market Overview

UIUC's record enrollment of about 60,848 students in 2025-2026 creates strong demand for affordable, quick meals near campus. Korean fried chicken (KFC) is surging nationally, with U.S. locations up 22% yearly, appealing to students via trendy flavors like honey garlic. College students prioritize inexpensive, late-night options, averaging fast-food visits frequently.^{[4] [2] [1]}

Competition Analysis

Green Street features diverse fast-casual spots like Shawarma Joint, Thai Fusion, burgers, and sandwiches, but no dedicated Korean fried chicken outlet. Yogi Korean Restaurant at 608 E Green St serves Korean dishes including fried chicken, acting as the closest direct rival in a casual format. This gap allows differentiation through KFC specialists like double-fried wings, absent from chains like Chick-fil-A nearby.^{[5] [6] [7] [8] [9]}

Competitor Type	Examples on Green St	Strengths	Weaknesses
Fast Casual Asian	Yogi Korean, Thai Fusion	Familiar flavors, student prices	Not KFC-focused, sit-down elements
American Fast Food	Epic Burger, Smith Burgers	Quick, cheap	Lacks K-dish novelty
Other Ethnic	Shawarma Joint	Variety, halal options	No chicken specialty

Budget Feasibility

A \$150,000 budget aligns with low-end fast-casual or pop-up startups, covering equipment (\$60k), build-out (\$45k), and fixtures (\$45k). Quick-service models range \$80k-\$250k, feasible for a small 1,200 sq ft space with minimal staff. Risks include tight margins; prioritize second-generation leases to cut costs 20-30%.^{[10] [11] [12]}

Target Audience Fit

UIUC students (mostly 18-22, budget-conscious) favor fast, flavorful food under \$10-15 per meal, matching KFC's portable tenders and sauces. High Asian/international enrollment boosts appeal for authentic twists like gochujang glaze. Late hours (till 11 PM+) capture post-class/study demand on bustling Green St.^{[13] [2] [3] [1]}

Concept Plan

Core Offering

Specialize in double-fried Korean fried chicken: bone-in/boneless pieces in sauces (soy garlic, spicy red, honey mustard). Add rice bowls, fries, and kimchi slaw for \$8-14.^{[14] [4]}

Menu Highlights

- 8-piece wings/boneless: \$12
- Chicken rice bowl: \$10
- Sides: Pickled radish, tteokbokki sticks (\$4)
- Drinks: Soju-inspired sodas, boba tea (\$3)

Operations

1,000-1,500 sq ft space; counter-service with 4-6 staff/shift. Hours: 11 AM-11 PM daily, extending weekends. Online ordering via DoorDash for dorm delivery.^[7]

Marketing

- UIUC Instagram/TikTok: "Crispiest K-chicken on Green" challenges.
- Student discounts (10% with ID), loyalty app for free sides.
- Pop-up tastings pre-launch.^[14]

Financial Snapshot

Aim for \$40k monthly revenue at \$12 avg check, 150 daily customers (feasible via foot traffic). Break-even in 4-6 months post-\$150k outlay, focusing on 30% food cost. Secure \$50k equipment lease to preserve cash.^{[15] [11] [10]}

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4. <https://www.circana.com/post/south-korean-restaurant-locations-in-the-u-s-grow-10-over-the-past-year-amid-surge-in-demand-for-k>

5. https://www.reddit.com/r/UIUC/comments/tjn39ts/best_restaurants_on_green_street/
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